

Pastoral Letter from My heart to yours, during Holy Week, 2022

By Priest Seraphim Holland

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Dear Brothers and Sisters, here are a few notes about Holy week. It's very important that we **live** holy week! We should do our very best to enter into the spirit of Holy Week, and as I told you before, it's very much about our relationship with Jesus Christ. Preserve the reactions of people when they encounter Jesus Christ, and glean things to do and not to do.

Read the first Great Passion Gospel, John 13:31-18:1 EVERY DAY!

I recently watched an incredibly good video with subtitles (<https://youtu.be/Nalbh57GT1s>, English Transcript: <https://otelders.org/theology-and-spirituality/how-to-live-holy-week-here-are-met-neophytos-tips-orthodox-cyprus/>) from Bishop Neophytos about this. He said that it was a custom amongst very holy men that he knew (he had the pleasure of knowing several saints of our time) to read the first Passion Gospel (the first of the 12 Gospels that are read on Holy Thursday evening, in matins), every single day during Holy Week, and even all the way until Pentecost.

The first great passion gospel, is the gospel that contains the 17th chapter of course, which is about His high priestly prayer. And it has many other things about the giving of the Holy Spirit and the Holy Trinity. Please pay particular attention to the questions of the apostles and put yourself in their place. It is perhaps the most profound gospel excerpt that exists in the universe. One could argue that the sermon on the Mount is more profound, or perhaps the beginning of the Gospel of John but this gospel is truly amazing and if you read it over and over (it'll take you maybe 15 or 20 minutes) every single day, you'll start to enter into the spirit of Holy Week.

I'm actually giving you all an assignment to do this. I know that there are things you must do and that it's hard for you to find time to read. And some of you are not in the habit of reading, but I'm still going to give you the assignment, and I'm going to hope that you will say: "this is a really good opportunity for me to practice obedience, because this is a good idea."

So, therefore, your assignment is to read this gospel every day during Holy Week and Bright Week. As your pastor, I'm telling you that what I'm going to do is read that gospel every day and I've already done it on Monday and Tuesday along with the other things that I'm trying to read during the week. If you just read this gospel every day you will be

benefited greatly! It's a very long gospel but it's really profound and beautiful, and the more you read it, the more things will enter into your soul. Please do this.

The video that I watched is, I believe, from God's mouth to my ear and now it is from my mouth to your ear, and may it be blessed that we read this gospel.

TO THE CATECHUMENS

I want to let the catechumens know that this is what we're going to study the Gospel in detail in our catechism. We're going to go through this line by line and apply it to our lives and I think it's going to be very profitable for us. I will ask you if you have read it every day!

PASCHA BASKETS

Lets' talk about the Pascha baskets. It is our custom in our church, to bless the Pascha baskets after the Paschal services on Sunday morning, about three o'clock in the morning. We do not bless them before this, with no exceptions. I understand that many other parishes bless the baskets before the Paschal services, and some even wear their priests out by having blessings every hour, on the hour, all of Holy Saturday afternoon, into the evening, like some sort of assembly line. It's really unfortunate that they do this because they run the poor priests ragged and it's not really beneficial to people who aren't normally churchgoers to get their Pascha basket blessed and then for them to go home and be eating meat and cheese and eggs when they should be in church worshiping God. There is also another great hidden loss that people are not aware of when the priest is busy blessing baskets on Holy Saturday and running to and fro doing things. The priest is responsible for preparing his soul to celebrate the liturgy calmly and with joy. There will be great grace during the Paschal liturgy but if the priest is run ragged, it will be difficult for him to convey this grace to the people.

I understand that there might be some need because a person has young children or is unwell or something like that. Therefore, we will also bless Pascha baskets at Agape Vespers, which we serve at 3pm on Pascha (Sunday afternoon). Those are the two main opportunities, and if someone has an extreme need, then we will bless their basket on any day during Bright week. The church teaches that every day of the Bright Week is Pascha; it is the same day! It may not feel like this to you, since you have slept and gotten up with the sun each day, but the church considers it to be the "eighth day", the one long day of Pascha: Bright week. Therefore, if your Pascha basket is blessed on Bright Monday, it is blessed on Pascha! There is no extra blessing to having the basket blessed Sunday morning. The entire week is blessed, exactly the same, because it is exactly the same day. We don't believe in magic, we believe in grace, and the grace of God is liberally given to us during the entire day Pascha.

What else could I tell you about this week? I want to emphasize again to you that this is an opportunity for us to enter into the person of Jesus Christ, evaluate our relationship with Him, and struggle to have our hearts open up a little bit. Listen to the Gospels

carefully! They will give you many opportunities to make this evaluation. You will see the good and the bad, the ugly, ignorant; you will see broken hearts, hardened hearts; you will see confusion; and through it all, you will see the gentle frankness of Jesus Christ, who knows exactly what's going to happen and also knows that those who love Him are confused and scared. We all get confused and scared. Entering into Holy Week teaches us what to do when we become confused and scared.

I beg you to take this opportunity to do this. You should fast strictly (therefore, try to fast strictly, but don't become obsessed if you cannot meet the mark you have given for yourself. The most important achievement during this week is open up your heart so that when grace comes, your heart will be filled). If you haven't been fasting strictly you could try to do it now, and you should come to the services, if you're able (and don't be too easy on yourself).

The most important services, if you must be selective because of children and other needs, are definitely:

- The 12 passion gospels on Thursday night (6 pm),
- The Lamentations on Friday evening (6 pm. Very "kid-friendly" and I daresay "cool" because we process around the church in the darkness with our candles singing. There is a beautiful mood during this procession),
- The Great Saturday divine liturgy (11 am) with the 15 readings, all about the resurrection. This is the first time that the Gospel of the resurrection is proclaimed.

And of course, it should go without saying that we should do everything in our power to be at the church by 11:30 Saturday evening so that we can process around the church and begin the Paschal matins by singing "Christ is risen!" In our parish, the children tend to do very well. They are up for the procession and then they go to sleep, and then usually they are up for communion with more energy than any of us! Don't be afraid to bring your children, and let them sleep during the majority of the service. Bring blankets and pillows and other such things that they might need. We will empty the baby room so there's lots of room for children to sleep.

On Sunday morning, when we proclaim the resurrection, we are doing it for the second time! If you were one of the apostles or disciples or myrrh-bearing women, you certainly would not want to find out about the resurrection **after** everyone else! You would want to know as soon as possible. We act a little bit like the apostles and the myrrh-bearing women when we attend the Holy Saturday liturgy and await the proclamation of the resurrection by the reading of the Gospel of St. Matthew in front of the holy tomb.

I recommended at least those services, but all the other ones are fantastic as well and the more you put into it, the more you get out of it, just like anything else in life. It's critical for us to struggle and it's critical for us to kind of pay attention to ourselves, watch our passions, say our prayers, and continue doing our prostrations. And please remember to read the first Holy Thursday Great Passion Gospel, John 13:31-18:1, every day this week!

May God bless you and help you in all things.

Unworthy Priest Seraphim, who prays for you, and sings “Christ is risen” to his grandchildren, all year round!